

SUMMER EVENTS | Philly Folk Festival | Sewickley | Welsh Town Names

JULY/AUGUST 2009 • VOL. 32, NO. 1

Pennsylvania

magazine

Adventure on the **PINE CREEK** RAIL TRAIL

Photo Contest Winners

Mount Gretna

Sine's Five and Dime

July/August 2009 • \$4.50



0 71896 00012 2

CYCLING IN THE Canyon

Encounters with
history and nature
abound along the
Pine Creek Rail Trail
at the bottom of
Pennsylvania's
Grand Canyon

Text and photos by Cindy Ross



WOOD HICK SAMUEL BARBOUR held a dangerous job in the 1880s. His days began with sitting on a large rock on the rim of the Pennsylvania Grand Canyon and peering into the 1,000-plus-foot abyss, looking for logjams in the Pine Creek below.

When he spied one, he'd hightail it down the near-vertical slope to the Owasee Rapids, where he'd hop on top of the monstrous old-growth log pile, and with the help of a long pole or, occasionally, dynamite, skillfully twist and turn the jumbled heap until the logs broke free. The job eventually cost him his life, and the rock, which he sat upon and which cyclists now pass by along the Pine Creek Rail Trail, is named in his honor.

Today, the logjams, tanneries and lumber camps of Barbour's era are gone, as is the railroad that hauled the ancient trees out of the forest. But, following the old railroad grade and wandering

Bob Scheidt cycles along Pine Creek on the rail bed that once carried trains laden with logs from the surrounding forest.

through a few remaining villages strung out along the waterway, the 62-mile gravel Pine Creek Rail Trail takes bikers and hikers along the floor of the Pine Creek Gorge. Here, in the Northcentral Mountains of Pennsylvania, history and nature are tucked into every corner of this remote and beautiful area, which was recognized in 1968 as a Natural National Landmark. Cliffs and steep-sided mountains tower over much of the creek, creating canyon depths in excess of 1,400 feet in some places. Black bear, white-tailed deer, wild turkeys, bobcats, river otters, beavers and bald eagles call the Pennsylvania Grand Canyon their home. Surrounded by a million acres of state forest and parkland, the multipurpose trail follows the route of the old New York Central Railroad from Middlebury Center, Tioga County, in the north to the town of Jersey Shore, Lycoming County, in the south.

For the next two days, my family and I are leading two young boys, Cullen and Shaun, along the trail for their first experience in adventure biking. We plan to spice up the ride with hikes to waterfalls, climbs to the rim for spectacular vistas, and swims in the cool creek.

On the Pine Creek Path, we bike the same route that the Iroquois and the Seneca used in their travels north and south.

Following the Trail of the Indians

On the first day of our trek, Merlin Benner, a certified wildlife biologist with Nature Quest, a local ecoadventure company, joins us to point out highlights that an uninformed cyclist might miss. Today's journey on the northern section of the trail will take us through the Marshcreek Wetlands, an important natural area.

As we pedal through this broad valley, the large ponds we pass contain a unique variety of species, including various rails, American bittern, green heron and other wetland birds and waterfowl. Just north of here is a large great blue heron rookery containing 25 to 30 birds, and the oldest, most successfully breeding pair of bald eagles in the state has a nest south of our location. These two eagles have been producing young for 22 years and are one of at least four pairs of bald eagles to nest in the canyon.

Cattails, bush dogwoods, alders and willows rim the ponds, which are covered with duckweed, the world's smallest flowering plant. Trails made by muskrats, beavers and perhaps mink and otter are etched into the green, solid-looking surface of the duckweed. A split-rail fence and Queen Anne's lace border the bike trail here, and as we move closer toward the gorge, the mountains close in and become nearly vertical around us.

Because the growing season in the Northcentral Mountains is too brief to support agriculture, the American Indians who once lived here adopted a seminomadic lifestyle, moving as necessary to find game and harvestable plants. On the Pine Creek Path, we bike the same route that the Iroquois and the Seneca used in their travels north and south. For hundreds of years, they would gather by the banks

of the creek to hunt elk, fish for native trout, and prepare for the winter by smoking and drying their food. At Big Meadows, near the village of present-day Ansonia, the Indians built longhouses, 60 feet long, and it is here that we stop for lunch. The longhouses are long gone, but in their place is the modern Nature Quest shelter, which is lashed together with saplings and rope and covered with a canvas roof.

Nourished from our lunch, we return to the trail and continue our ride, hoping to catch sight of an authentic covered wagon, pulled by draft horses, which a historian from Mountain Trail Horse Ranch frequently leads along this wider portion of the trail. Beside us, the river is a constant companion, and the curving, twisting trail ensures that we never get bored.

When we reach Tiadaghton, which means "River of Pines" in Iroquois, Merlin leads us on a half-mile hike up Campbell Run, a narrow side canyon full of immense old-growth hemlocks, a creek bed full of shattered sandstone shale, and two magnificent 30- to 35-foot waterfalls. The rocks, some as large as flagstones, are pockmarked with fossils, mostly bivalves, including clams and oysters.

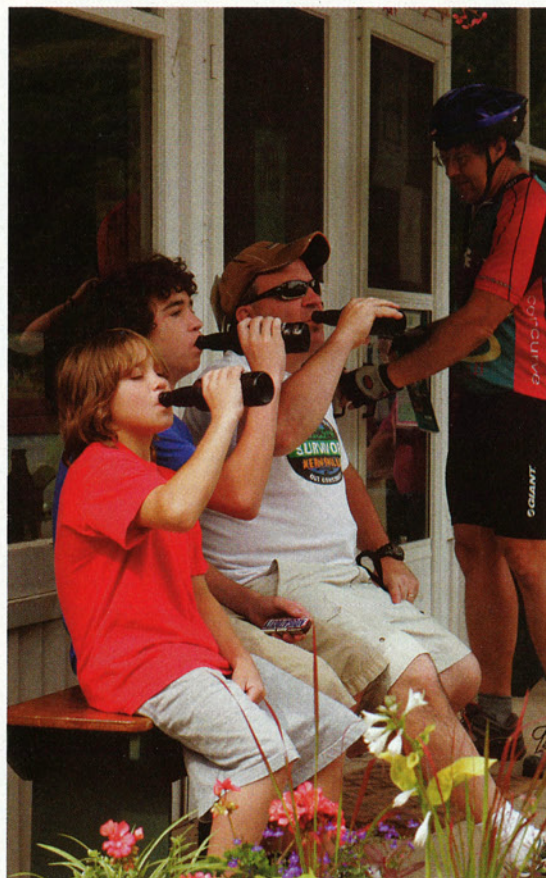
We follow an old cast-iron pipe that was used in the 1880s to carry water down to the steam locomotives traveling the valley. The pipe leads us to a stone dam and the remnants of a leaf-covered reservoir, where the falls tumble over a curved bowl of stacked shale. The boys strip down to shorts and lunge into the mountain ice water to cool off in the green pool. The Pine Creek and many of its tributaries are prime native-trout streams, and some cyclists will carry collapsible rods on their bikes to take advantage of the angling.

Harvesting Ginseng and Logs

While cycling near the village of Blackwell, we hit a patch of loose gravel and a member of our group wipes out, shredding her knee and skinning her elbow. Just as we were wishing we had hydrogen peroxide to clean out her wounds, a lady suddenly appears carrying a bottle in her hand.

"Did someone say they needed hydrogen peroxide?" she asks.

She invites us into her nearby house so that we can administer first aid, and as we follow her there, we tell the boys that this woman is called a "trail angel" in the world of cycling adventurers, and our encounter with her is what we term "trail magic."



John Mikulsky points out highlights from the overlook on Hemlock Mountain to Andy Alban, an Ecuadorian exchange student.

(left) Stopping for some cold refreshment at Cedar Run General Store along the way.

Our "trail angel" tells us that she is a direct descendent of the first white settlers to arrive in this valley in the early 1770s. A century later, many pioneers received land grants in return for their military service during the Civil War, and they made a living by lumbering, farming, fishing and trapping. In the early 20th century, entrepreneurs from Blackwell harvested ginseng that grew wild in the woods and that they eventually learned to cultivate as a cash crop. From the 1920s to 1940s, during the heyday of the ginseng operation, Chinese buyers would travel by train from Philadelphia to Blackwell to purchase the tuberous roots.

But most of the people who settled in the Pine Creek Valley and the surrounding lands were interested in logging the majestic white pines that grew up to four feet wide and 150 feet high, the perfect size to be turned into masts for wooden clipper ships. During the height of the lumbering season, the fields on either side of Pine Creek would hold stacks of logs, 30 to 40 feet high, which would be floated down the river when the spring melt occurred.

The logs were brought into the big mills in Williamsport, a town that once housed the most millionaires in the country. To accommodate the demand for this lumber, 145 sawmills

sprang up throughout the hills. Once all of the white pines were harvested, the loggers turned their saws on hemlocks, and then hardwoods, until by 1910 barely a tree remained on the canyon hillsides.

Blackened stumps and a jungle of berry thickets had replaced the dense old growth, and the canyon was nicknamed a "Pennsylvania desert." With the soil depleted of nutrients, fires baked the ground, landslides filled the creek with mud and debris, and once-clear waters ran poisoned and black with chemicals, bark and ooze. The state bought the destroyed land from the logging companies for less than \$2 an acre, and the long, uphill march to healing and preserving the land was begun. Because of these efforts, the forest today has returned lush and gorgeous, and it's difficult to imagine such devastation.

We arrive at our campsite for the evening, a spot rimmed with majestic white pines, whose soft, long needles swoosh in the breeze. Hoffman Campground's eight sites, complete with picnic tables, a bathroom and water pump, are specifically for hikers, bikers and paddlers, and no vehicular travel is allowed. Like other campgrounds along the trail, this one is free, but reservations are recommended.

One mile below our camp, jutting into the river, is Rattlesnake Rock, named for the rattlesnakes that like to hang out under the shale cliffs just north of here. Snakes are a part of the canyon's fauna, and educational signs along the trail aim to alert and educate cyclists about these reptiles.



(top to bottom) Dusk comes to Hoffman Campground with a view of the Pine Creek valley. Cullen Donmoyer enjoys the spray of the waterfall in the slate-filled Campbell Run. Joe Donmoyer and his son, Shaun, roast hot dogs at Hoffman Campground.



The Rattlesnake Rock Access Area is a put-in spot for paddlers; it is also the trailhead for the 30-mile-long West Rim Trail, which travels along the rim of the canyon. We pull our empty trailers one mile to a nearby parking lot where we retrieve a portable grill, charcoal, a cooler and goodies for dinner from the vehicles we had left there. The next morning, Cullen's and Shaun's mother arrives, towing her sons' red wagon, which contains a thermos of coffee, donuts and some fresh strawberries for breakfast.

Encounters with Wildlife

On our second day, we bike four miles to the sleepy village of Cedar Run, where a historical general store and B&B are located. At the store, we treat ourselves to hand-dipped ice cream cones and old-fashioned root beer in glass bottles as we sit astride a barrel and play checkers. In recent years, Cedar Run, once a prosperous logging community with tanneries and sawmills, has been transformed into a popular destination for trout anglers.

We leave the bike trail in the tiny hamlet of Slate Run for a climb up Hemlock Mountain. From the apex, we can look north to where we had just ridden, before hiking a tenth of a mile to the other side of the flat mountaintop to gaze into the canyon where we will be heading next. The steep climb is well worth the view. The gorge stretches beneath our feet, and the river is a thin strand below layers of green mountains.

After descending, we find a deep swimming hole at the point where Little Slate Run joins Pine Creek, and someone from our group volunteers to cycle back to the general store to purchase a six-pack of Blue Moon beer. As we sit in the tepid water, passing bottles for sips, a bald eagle soars low over our heads. We watch enraptured as the setting sun lights up the eagle's wings like molten fire.

On the ride back to the campground, we have to stop at one point to allow a large black bear to lumber across the trail. She points her nose in our direction before continuing into the woods.

As our adventure wraps up, we reflect on our cycling trip through Pennsylvania's Grand Canyon and our grand encounters with history and nature. If you can measure success by how many people you turn on to adventure cycling, then the Pine Creek Rail Trail has worked its magic. In only a few short days, Cullen and Shaun tell us, they have become fans of the sport. ♣

—Cindy Ross of New Ringgold regularly enjoys adventure trips with her family and friends.

When You Go

The **Pine Creek Rail Trail** is a 60-plus-mile, hard-packed gravel surface available to hikers and bikers. Horses may be taken on designated sections. The trail travels through Pennsylvania's Grand Canyon gorge in Tioga and Lycoming counties. With its 2 percent grade over the entire length, the trail has been voted by *USA Today* as one of the "10 great places to take a bike tour."

For more information, contact the Tioga County Visitors Bureau at 888-TIOGA28 (846-4228) or www.visittiogapa.com. ■